# Scalable Extraction of Author-Stated Research Gaps: Towards Automated Idea Generation

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**Abstract**

Research gaps stated by authors could feed automated idea generation, but they are rare and scattered in papers. Asking a large language model (LLM) to judge every sentence, or a whole paper at once, is expensive, and long inputs are hard for smaller models. We propose a hierarchical three-stage funnel that splits the task: rules drop unlikely text, a zero-shot natural-language-inference classifier flags candidate gaps, and an LLM filters the candidates as source sentences. A single instruction sets the filter to favour precision, balance or recall. We evaluated the funnel on two human-labelled benchmarks, SAL (limitations in randomized-trial reports) and FWS (future work in natural language processing papers). Because each covers one gap type in one field, we also built a corpus of 230 arXiv and biomedical papers labelled by LLMs for limitations, future work and research gaps. In its high-precision setting, the LLM filter more than doubled precision on SAL, from 29.1% after the classifier to 66.2%, while keeping 84.9% recall, and on every dataset the three settings traded precision for recall as intended. With a 27-billion-parameter LLM, the funnel matched or exceeded whole-paper prompting on both human-labelled benchmarks with about a third of the input tokens, but was weaker on the arXiv papers. With a 4-billion-parameter LLM, whole-paper prompting failed on long arXiv papers ($F_1$ 0.30 against LLM labels), whereas the funnel reached 0.54.

**Keywords:** research gap extraction; limitations; future work; scientific text mining; large language models; natural language inference; zero-shot classification; LLM filtering

## 1 Introduction

Research papers often say where a study falls short and what should be done next. In clinical research, self-acknowledged limitations help readers judge a trial's design, data and applicability [1]. In other fields, future-work statements name the extensions and open questions that authors consider worth pursuing [2, 3], and authors point to unsolved problems in their field when they motivate their own work. We call these statements *author-stated research gaps*: limitations of the authors' own work, future-work directions they propose, and open problems they identify. Collected across many papers, they are a natural input for automated idea generation, because each one is a claim, made by a domain expert, about what is still missing.

Gap statements are hard to find for four reasons. They are rare: in the test sets we use, they make up 2.6% of the sentences of randomized controlled trial (RCT) reports, 5.7% of full arXiv and biomedical papers and 14.6% of conclusion sections. They are scattered: a limitation may sit in a dedicated section, in the discussion or next to a methodological choice, and in

computer-science papers many gaps appear in the methods and experiments sections. Many sentences look like gaps without being one, such as a criticism of prior work or a restated result. And the output must stay attributable: a system that writes plausible criticism answers a different question from one that finds what the authors actually wrote [4, 5].

A large language model (LLM) can judge whether a sentence states a gap; the question is how to give it the paper. Judging every sentence separately is expensive. Giving the model the whole paper asks it to find a few sentences among tens of thousands of tokens, and LLMs use information in the middle of long inputs less reliably [6]. Earlier extraction work suggests a different division of labour: clinical limitation recognition uses section headings and lexical cues before supervised classifiers [1], and future-work recognition separates locating sentences from classifying them [2, 3].

We follow this idea with a three-stage funnel (Figure 1). Stage A removes text that is unlikely to contain gaps, Stage B selects candidate sentences with a zero-shot natural-language-inference (NLI) classifier, and Stage C asks an LLM to keep or drop each candidate. No stage rewrites text, so every output is a sentence the authors wrote. Stage B needs no gap-labelled training data, so the same funnel runs on biomedical and computer-science papers.

Stage C has three modes, set by one paragraph of its instruction: high precision, balanced and high recall. Because a false gap wastes effort in idea generation, precision is our primary goal, and high precision is the main mode.

We evaluate the funnel on two benchmarks with human labels, self-acknowledged limitations in RCT reports (SAL) [7] and future-work sentences in natural language processing (NLP) papers (FWS) [3], and on 230 arXiv and biomedical papers that we labelled for all three gap types with LLMs. We compare the funnel with giving the same LLM the whole paper, using a 27B and a 4B model. We ask four questions:

- **RQ1 (stages).** How much does each stage change precision and recall on full papers?
- **RQ2 (precision control).** Does one instruction set the precision–recall trade-off of the LLM filter consistently across datasets?
- **RQ3 (whole-paper prompting).** How does the funnel compare with giving the same LLM the whole paper, in accuracy and cost, and does the answer depend on the size of the LLM?
- **RQ4 (classifier).** Is a training-free classifier enough for Stage B, compared with a classifier trained on human labels or one fine-tuned on our LLM labels?

We also test cheaper formats for the Stage C calls.

Our main findings are:

1. **Precision can be set with one instruction.** On every dataset, moving from high recall to high precision raises precision and lowers recall. In high-precision mode the funnel reaches 66.2% precision on SAL (from 29.1% after Stage B, at 84.9% recall) and 76.5% on FWS (Section 4.2).
2. **With a strong LLM, the funnel matches whole-paper prompting at a third of the input.** With Qwen3.8-27B, the funnel has higher $F_1$ on both human-labelled benchmarks, significantly only on FWS, and uses about a third of the input tokens. On arXiv papers, scored against labels that were themselves made from whole papers, whole-paper prompting is better (Section 4.3).
3. **The funnel keeps a small LLM usable on long papers.** With Qwen3.5-4B, whole-paper prompting breaks down on arXiv papers ($F_1$ 0.30 in high-precision mode, against LLM labels), whereas the funnel reaches 0.54 with the same model. The gain comes from the longer papers (Section 4.3).

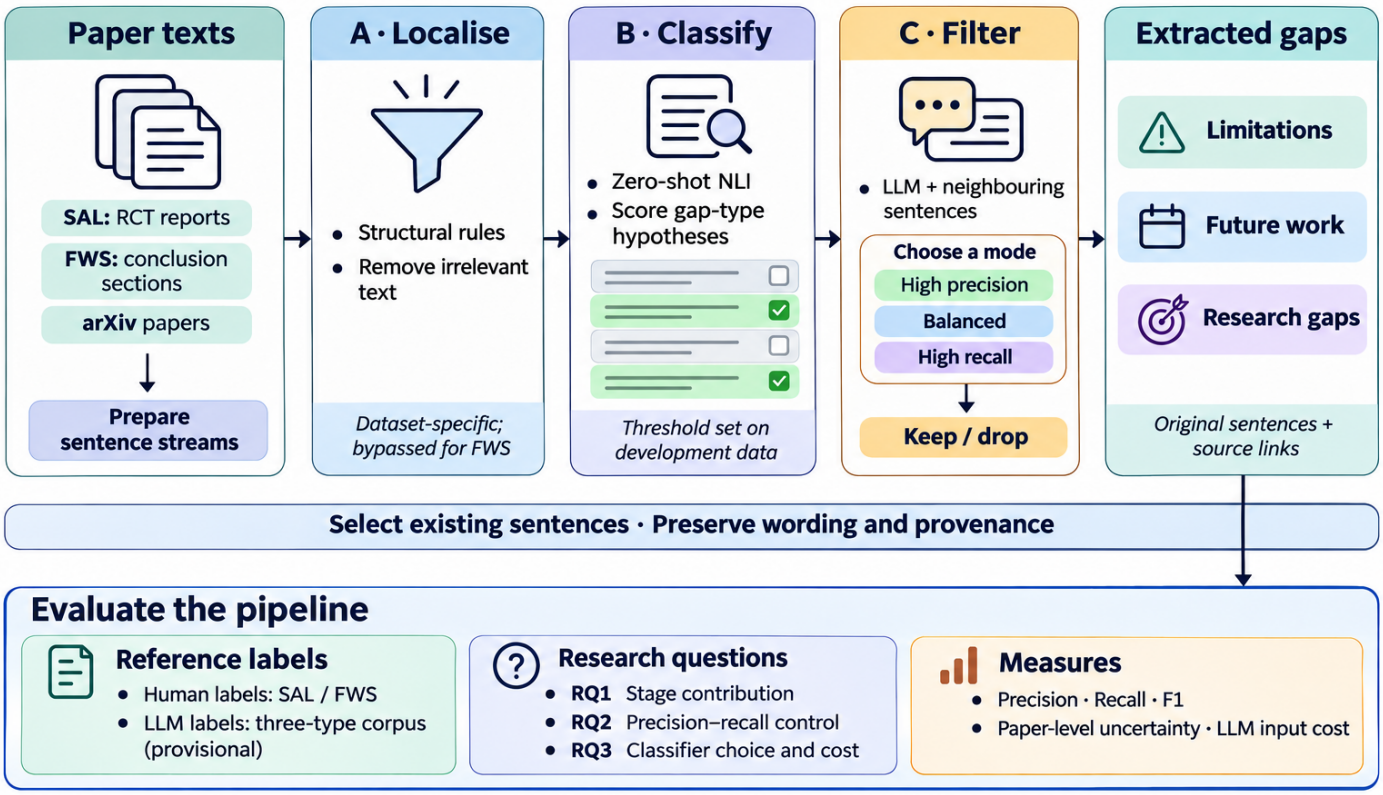



**Figure 1:** Overview of the funnel. Each paper is split into sentences. Stage A removes text that is unlikely to contain gaps (its rules depend on the dataset; FWS skips it), Stage B selects candidate sentences with a zero-shot NLI classifier, and Stage C asks an LLM to keep or drop each candidate. The three filter modes are alternative instructions for Stage C, not consecutive steps. Every output is an original sentence with its source. Evaluation uses human labels on SAL (limitations) and FWS (future work), and provisional LLM labels for all three gap types.

4. **A training-free Stage B is competitive.** On SAL, in high-precision mode, it comes within 0.021 $F_1$ of a supervised PubMedBERT. The supervised model is 8.4 points more precise. Fine-tuning the NLI model on our LLM labels helps against those labels but not against human labels (Section 4.4).

5. **Evaluation data needs checking.** Letter case alone reveals the label in the public FWS corpus, and the precision of the same output is 66.2% against human labels and 93.2% against LLM labels (Sections 4.6.1 and 4.6.2).

The scope of this paper is extraction. Whether an extracted gap is still open, and whether it leads to a useful research idea, are separate questions. Section 2 reviews related work. Section 3 describes the data, the funnel and the comparisons. Section 4 reports the results, Section 5 discusses them and the limitations of the study, and Section 6 concludes.

## 2 Related Work

Gap2Idea builds on research into scientific discourse classification, the recognition of author-stated limitations and future work, and LLM-based analysis of scholarly documents. Across these areas, similar terminology can refer to different tasks: locating an existing statement, inferring a missing piece of knowledge, or generating a new criticism or research direction. We organise the discussion around these distinctions and explain how each line of work informs our funnel. Table 1 compares the closest studies by target, method and input unit.

### 2.1 Scientific discourse and sentence classification

Scientific discourse annotation provides a foundation for identifying statements by their role within a paper. Argumentative zoning represents the rhetorical function of sentences and their relationship to the authors' argument [8]. Liakata et al. [9] distinguish this rhetorical perspective from Core Scientific Concepts (CoreSC), which represent components of an investigation, including its goals, methods, observations and conclusions. The Dr. Inventor corpus brings the discussion closer to our targets: its 40 computer-graphics articles have a Future Work category in the argumentative-structure layer and a Limitation category among the crosswise features [10]. These annotations establish a full-text precedent for representing both kinds of statement, although they do not constitute a single research-gap detection task.

Abstract sentence classification supplies further resources and modelling approaches. PubMed 200k RCT and CSAbstruct support the recognition of abstract roles in biomedical and computer-science publications, respectively [11, 12]. MAZEA allows multiple rhetorical labels per sentence [13], while Emerald 110k extends coverage across disciplines and includes a combined Research limitations/implications heading [14]. Such resources provide useful discourse supervision, but their labels and document scope differ from ours: a conclusion sentence need not state a gap, and a combined limitations/implications label also covers other content.

More targeted rhetorical schemes make the overlap explicit. Sci-Sentence includes Research Gap and Limitation among seven categories intended to support literature-review analysis [15]. Its benchmark samples sentences from introductions, related-work sections and limitations sections. Its Research Gap category overlaps with our open-problem target, whereas its Limitation definition concerns weaknesses of a previous study rather than exclusively the authors' own work. This difference in attribution matters when deciding which statements count as positives.

Context is another shared concern. Hierarchical sentence classifiers model surrounding discourse [16], and Brack et al. [17] investigate cross-domain sequential classification through multi-task learning. Lan et al. [18] extend sequential classification to LLMs and multi-label outputs, while Zhang and Zhang [19] use context-enhanced representations to identify problem

and method sentences. These studies motivate considering neighbouring text when a sentence is ambiguous. In Gap2Idea, local context is supplied to the final LLM filter, which decides whether a previously selected candidate expresses the target statement.

### 2.2 Recognition of limitations and future work

Work on self-acknowledged limitations directly addresses one of our three targets. Kilicoglu et al. [1] formulate limitation recognition in clinical research as sentence-level binary classification and investigate both rules and learned classifiers. Their use of section headings and limitation zones provides a direct precedent for structural localisation. Lan et al. [7] subsequently annotate limitations in 200 RCT publications and separate detecting a limitation from assigning its type. Their fine-tuned PubMedBERT detector achieves a reported $F_1$ of 0.821 under their evaluation protocol. SAL supplies our human-labelled limitation benchmark, and the PubMedBERT model family supplies a supervised comparison. We distinguish that published score from our full-paper evaluation because the evaluated sentence pool and class balance affect precision and $F_1$.

Future-work recognition has a parallel history. Zhu et al. [2] use BERT-based recognition to identify future-research sentences in JASIST articles and cluster the extracted statements. The ACL FWS-RC corpus provides annotations and a taxonomy for future-work sentences in NLP papers [20]. Using this resource, Zhang et al. [3] compare lexical and neural approaches, reporting their strongest binary recognition result with Bernoulli naive Bayes (macro-$F_1$ of 0.9073). Their recognition and direction-classification tasks are distinct, as are macro-$F_1$ and the positive-class $F_1$ used in our main evaluation. These published scores therefore provide context rather than a ranking against our paper-disjoint experiments.

Extracted statements also support analysis beyond detection. Suray et al. [21] examine how subsequent usable-security research engages with previously stated future work. More recently, Thaepprasit et al. [22] analyse self-reported limitations in ACL and EMNLP papers through iterative human–AI qualitative coding. These studies show how author-written statements can support research-trend and reporting analyses. Gap2Idea addresses the preceding extraction step; it does not establish whether a stated gap remains unresolved or whether a proposed direction has subsequently been pursued.

### 2.3 LLM extraction, inferred gaps and generated critique

LLMs are increasingly used both to extract statements and to produce new assessments of research. BAGELS constructs limitation data from ACL, NeurIPS and PeerJ papers, supplements author-written material with external reviews, and studies retrieval-augmented limitation generation [23]. FutureGen similarly uses extracted future-work material to support the generation and evaluation of new directions [24]. Cheng et al. [25] directly investigate prompted LLM extraction of future-work sentences in NLP papers and connect the extracted material to keyword-based research-direction analysis. Their pipeline selects relevant sections before LLM processing. Together, these studies establish that both LLM extraction and structural selection already have close precedents.

Knowledge-gap identification also includes an inference task. GAPMAP explicitly distinguishes stated biomedical knowledge gaps from missing knowledge inferred from context, evaluating LLMs in paragraph-level and full-paper settings [26]. This distinction is central to our scope: we select an existing sentence that articulates a gap and preserve its wording. We do not ask the model to construct an implicit gap that has no corresponding author-written statement.

Limitation generation and scientific critique involve a further change in the source of the output. LimGen studies suggestive limitation generation using 4068 ACL papers and their associated author-written limitations [27]. Despite its similar name, LimitGen is a separate benchmark for evaluating LLM-generated limitations and feedback on AI research papers [4].

Tree-of-Concerns focuses specifically on unstated limitations through structured multi-agent critique [5]. These tasks can produce useful criticisms beyond those acknowledged by the authors. Our LLM instead returns a keep-or-drop decision for each candidate sentence; the resulting extraction remains attributable to the original text.

### 2.4 Position of this work

Our Stage B builds on established methodology. Yin et al. [28] formulate zero-shot text classification as textual entailment, allowing a label to be expressed as a natural-language hypothesis. We apply this formulation to gap types using an existing NLI model. Here, zero-shot means that the classifier is not fitted on gap-detection training examples; the model has already been trained on NLI data, and our decision threshold is selected with labelled development data.

Our contribution is the evaluation of a particular combination: structural localisation, NLI candidate selection and a context-aware LLM filter with three precision–recall instructions. We examine how these stages interact, how the filter settings behave across datasets, and how the funnel compares with giving the same LLM the whole paper, in accuracy and cost, for LLMs of different sizes. Long inputs are a known difficulty for LLMs [6], and this comparison measures how much a filter in front of the LLM helps on full scientific papers. The evaluation covers both full papers and the section-level FWS resource, keeping their processing units and label sources explicit. Human-labelled limitation and future-work benchmarks support those two targets; findings for the joint three-type task remain provisional because that corpus is LLM-labelled. The resulting evidence concerns source-preserving extraction; assessing the quality of research ideas derived from these statements remains a separate task.

## 3 Materials and Methods

This section defines the task and the data, describes the three stages of the funnel and how their settings were chosen, and then introduces the systems we compare against and the evaluation protocol.

### 3.1 Task

Given a paper as a sequence of sentences, the system selects the sentences in which the authors state a research gap. We distinguish three types:

- **Limitation**: a weakness, caveat, bias, constraint or assumption the authors acknowledge about their own work;
- **Future work**: an explicit direction the authors propose for future research;
- **Research gap**: an unsolved problem, missing capability or open challenge the authors point to in the field or in prior work.

The system never rewrites or summarises; each output is an unmodified source sentence. Evaluation is binary at the sentence level: a returned sentence is correct if the reference labels mark it as a gap of a type the benchmark covers, and the predicted type is not scored. SAL labels only limitations and FWS only future work, so on these benchmarks the funnel is asked for that single type.

### 3.2 Data

We use three datasets (Table 2): two public benchmarks with human labels, each covering one gap type, and a corpus of 230 papers that we labelled for all three types with LLMs. Within each dataset, splits are made by paper.

**Table 1:** Selected related work, ordered by year of the cited version. Target categories describe the relevant part of each study; other rhetorical labels are omitted where applicable. When multiple target categories apply, they are listed in the order Limitations, Future work and Research gaps. "Input unit" is the input each method processes.

| Study | Domain | Target categories | Approach | Input unit | Relation to this study |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Dr. Inventor, 2016 [10] | Computer graphics | Limitations; Future work | Human multi-layer annotation | Sentences, full articles | Full-text precedent with both statement types |
| Kilicoglu et al., 2018 [1] | Clinical research | Limitations | Rules; supervised classifiers | Sentences | Precedent for section-based localisation |
| Zhu et al., 2019 [2] | Information science | Future work | BERT classification; clustering | Sentences, full articles | Links recognition to thematic analysis |
| ACL FWS-RC, 2020 [20] | NLP | Future work | Annotation; taxonomy | Sentences | Source of FWS labels |
| Zhang et al., 2022 [3] | NLP | Future work | Lexical and neural recognition | Sentences | FWS recognition benchmark |
| LimGen, 2024 [27] | NLP | Limitations | LLM generation | Paper | Author limitation sections as references |
| Lan et al. (SAL), 2024 [7] | RCT reports | Limitations | PubMedBERT detection and typing | Sentences | Source of SAL; supervised comparison |
| Lan et al. (multi-label), 2024 [18] | Several sciences | Rhetorical roles | LLM prompting and fine-tuning | Abstract sequence | Context-aware LLM labelling |
| Zhang and Zhang, 2024 [19] | NLP | Problems; Methods | Context-enhanced transformer | Sentence with context | Local context for sparse targets |
| Brack et al., 2024 [17] | Several sciences | Rhetorical roles | Cross-domain multi-task learning | Sentence sequence | Transfer across domains |
| Suray et al., 2024 [21] | Usable security | Future work | Statement and citation analysis | Statement | Downstream use of extracted directions |
| BAGELS, 2025 [23] | NLP; machine learning; biology | Limitations | Extraction; retrieval-augmented generation | Paper; reviews | Extraction and generation benchmark |
| FutureGen, 2025 [24] | NLP; machine learning | Future work | LLM extraction; retrieval-augmented generation | Paper | Extraction feeding generation |
| GAPMAP, 2025 [26] | Biomedicine | Knowledge gaps | LLM detection and inference | Paragraph to paper | Explicit versus inferred gaps |
| LimitGen, 2025 [4] | AI | Limitations | LLM critique; retrieval | Paper | Evaluates generated limitations |
| Sci-Sentence, 2025 [15] | Several sciences | Limitations; Research gaps | Encoder and LLM classifiers | Sentence | Gap labels; different attribution |
| Tree-of-Concerns, 2026 [5] | machine learning; NLP; vision | Limitations | Multi-agent critique | Paper | Unstated critique; different target |
| Cheng et al., 2026 [25] | NLP | Future work | Section selection; LLM extraction | Selected sections | LLM extraction with structural selection |
| Thaepprasit et al., 2026 [22] | NLP | Limitations | Human–AI qualitative coding | Limitation sections | Downstream analysis of reported limitations |
| **This study** | RCT reports; NLP; arXiv | Limitations; Future work; Research gaps | Rules, zero-shot NLI, LLM filter with three modes | Sentence with context | Stage contribution, precision control, comparison with whole-paper prompting |

**Table 2:** Evaluation data. Positives are sentences labelled with a gap type the benchmark covers.

| Dataset (split) | Labels | Gap types | Papers | Sentences | Positives | Use |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAL-40 (test) | Human | Limitation | 40 | 7968 | 205 | Main evaluation |
| SAL dev | Human | Limitation | 40 | 7729 | 180 | Threshold; held-out check |
| FWS (test) | Human | Future work | 209 | 1506 | 220 | Evaluation |
| FWS (dev) | Human | Future work | 418 | 3005 | 418 | Threshold |
| Gold corpus (test) | LLM ensemble | All three | 34 | 11,741 | 664 | Evaluation |
| Gold corpus (validation) | LLM ensemble | All three | 34 | 11,201 | 699 | Design choices; thresholds |

**SAL.** SAL contains 200 RCT reports in which annotators marked the sentences that state a self-acknowledged limitation, split into 120 training, 40 development and 40 test papers [7, 29]. We call the test split SAL-40 and the development split SAL dev. We removed sentences of fewer than three words (none of the removed test sentences is a limitation) and otherwise evaluate on the full paper. To apply section rules in Stage A, we recovered each sentence's section by matching it to the PubMed Central BioC version of its article. The training split is used only to train the supervised classifiers in Section 3.5.

**FWS.** The FWS recognition corpus contains sentences from the conclusion sections of ACL papers, each labelled as future work or not [3, 20, 30]. Each "paper" is a conclusion excerpt of about seven sentences, so FWS has no full-paper structure; we use it to test the funnel on a second domain and a second gap type. We removed every sentence that also occurs in the training data of an earlier classifier of ours, shuffled the papers once, and took the first 209 papers (1506 sentences) as the test sample and the next 418 as the development sample. All FWS text is lowercased before any processing, for every system, because in this corpus letter case reveals the label (Section 4.6.2).

**Gold corpus.** To evaluate all three gap types together, we built the *gold corpus*: 230 papers and 68,719 sentences. It contains 190 arXiv computer-science and machine-learning papers and the 40 SAL-40 papers with their original sentence boundaries. The arXiv papers are a convenience sample collected during earlier development of this project, not a random sample; their identifiers and extracted text are in the repository. They were converted from PDF with PyMuPDF and split into sentences after removing reference lists. We call the corpus "gold" because its labels are our reference for three-type evaluation, but no person has checked them yet, so all results on it are provisional.

The labels were produced in two steps:

1. *Independent labelling.* Two LLMs, Claude Opus 5.5 and Claude Sonnet 5.5, each labelled every sentence of every paper, in one call per paper, following a written guideline with the three definitions above. SAL labels were not shown to them. They agreed on the type of 2960 sentences.

2. *Adjudication.* The remaining 1737 candidates, marked by only one model or with different types, were judged again by Claude Opus 5.5 with three sentences of context on each side. It confirmed 1502 of them.

The corpus has 4462 gap sentences: 2234 research gaps, 1543 limitations and 685 future-work statements. The two labelling models agreed on whether a sentence is a gap with $\kappa = 0.778$ [31], which measures consistency between the models, not agreement with people. On the 40 SAL papers, the ensemble marked all but nine of SAL's 205 human-labelled limitations as a gap; this shows high recall against SAL, not precision. Labelling cost about US$36.

Papers were split into 162 training, 34 validation and 34 test papers. The test split has 664 gaps (220 limitations, 97 future work, 347 research gaps); 28 of its papers are from arXiv (527 gaps) and 6 are SAL papers (137 gaps).

### 3.3 The funnel

The funnel applies three stages in sequence, each keeping a subset of the sentences it receives (Figure 1).

**Stage A: localisation.** Stage A removes text that is unlikely to contain gaps before any model runs. Its rules depend on the dataset, because papers differ in how reliably their sections show where gaps are stated.

- **SAL:** only sentences in Discussion and Conclusion sections are kept.
- **Gold corpus:** no section rule is applied, because in arXiv papers many gaps are stated in the methods and experiments sections (Section 5.4). Stage A instead applies exclusion rules, which we call the *junk filter*. It drops titles, tables, figure captions and abbreviation lists; competing-interest, author-contribution, funding and supplementary sections where section types are known; bibliography-like strings; and malformed sentences (under 25 characters or six tokens, starting mid-word, containing dot leaders, or consisting mostly of non-letters).
- **FWS:** there is no Stage A. The corpus already consists of conclusion sections, and the junk filter, which rejects sentences that start in lower case, would remove almost all of the lowercased text.

**Stage B: zero-shot NLI classifier.** Stage B selects candidates with a classifier that needs no gap-labelled training data. We use an NLI cross-encoder, ModernBERT-large fine-tuned on NLI data [32, 33], as a zero-shot classifier [28]: the model reads a sentence (the premise) with a short statement of the label (the hypothesis) and estimates whether the sentence entails it. There is one hypothesis per gap type: "This is a limitation.", "This is future work." and "This is a research gap." For each hypothesis, the entailment and contradiction probabilities are renormalised to sum to one, and the entailment share is the score. On the gold corpus, a sentence becomes a candidate if its highest score over the three hypotheses reaches a threshold $\tau$, and its predicted type is the hypothesis with that score. SAL uses only the limitation hypothesis and FWS only the future-work hypothesis. Inputs are truncated to 256 tokens.

**Stage C: LLM filter.** Stage C keeps or drops each candidate with an LLM. Candidates are sent in reading order, 20 per request. For each candidate, the model receives its predicted type, the sentence (up to 400 characters) and a context window of the sentence and its immediate neighbours in the same paper (up to 600 characters). It returns a keep or drop verdict for every candidate, as JSON constrained by a schema. The system prompt (Appendix A) defines the three gap types, lists the kinds of sentences to drop (results, method descriptions, contribution claims, background, citations, captions and similar), and contains one paragraph that sets the mode. Only this paragraph changes between modes:

- **High recall**: when genuinely uncertain, keep the sentence;
- **Balanced**: favour neither keeping nor dropping;
- **High precision**: keep a sentence only if it explicitly states the gap itself; drop general background, motivation, observed outcomes and passing remarks; when uncertain, drop it.

For SAL and FWS, the definitions are narrowed to the benchmark's single type and the other two types are added to the sentences to drop. The mode paragraphs are identical on all datasets.

Our main model is Qwen3.8-27B (`Qwen/Qwen3.8-27B-FP8`, revision `017b9c7a`), which was not used to create any labels. It is self-hosted with vLLM 0.32.0 [34] on one H100 GPU, with temperature 0, seed 0, no reasoning mode and speculative decoding with two draft tokens.

### 3.4 How settings were chosen

To make clear which data could have influenced each setting, we list where it was chosen.

- **NLI hypotheses.** We compared hypothesis variants (long definitions, short type names, one combined hypothesis, adding neighbouring sentences to the premise, and subtracting competing "not a gap" hypotheses) on one half of the gold validation papers and confirmed the choice on the other half. Short type names worked best.
- **Thresholds.** $\tau$ is set on development data only, as the highest threshold at which recall after Stage B is at least 90%, counting positives removed by Stage A or Stage B as missed. This gives 0.7286 on SAL dev and 0.1922 on FWS dev. On the gold corpus, $\tau = 0.354$ was set on the same half of the validation papers that was used to choose the hypotheses; the rule applied to all 34 validation papers would give 0.232 and more candidates. Stage B thus keeps most gaps and leaves the removal of false positives to Stage C.[1]
- **Stage C model, batch size and context.** These and the high-recall instruction were chosen during development on 196 candidates from 27 of the 34 gold test papers. We therefore also report gold results without these candidates.
- **Balanced and high-precision instructions.** These were written after reading false positives of a high-recall run on gold test papers, and checked on the gold validation split before any test run. All three modes were run on every test set and all are reported, so no mode was selected by its test score. The frozen prompts and run outputs are in the repository history from 5 November 2026; earlier development is not time-stamped.
- **Held-out check.** SAL dev was used only to set $\tau$; no prompt was written or chosen on it. Running the funnel on SAL dev therefore tests it on papers that influenced no prompt.

### 3.5 Comparison systems

**Whole-paper prompting.** The main alternative to the funnel is to give the same LLM the whole paper. The baseline was implemented, and its plan, prompts and code frozen, before any test call. Each call contains one paper as numbered sentences in reading order (one per line, "[id] sentence"), with no Stage A or B, and the model returns the ids of all sentences it judges to be gaps. The system prompt is the funnel's Stage C prompt in the same mode, with only its opening line and the description of the input and output changed. Answers are limited to 4096 tokens; a call that exceeds the limit fails and its gaps count as missed. The arXiv sentence boundaries are those of the gold corpus, so both approaches are scored on exactly the same sentences.

On FWS, the frozen plan used a single older prompt from our code base that accepts limitations as well as future work. The FWS baseline therefore has one result for all three modes, and its precision may be understated.

The same frozen plan also split each paper differently: into chunks of 100 consecutive sentences, and into batches of 20 consecutive sentences, which judges every sentence in the funnel's batch size but without Stages A and B. We report these as additional baselines for the 27B model.

[1] The stored thresholds are rounded. At the rounded SAL value one development limitation falls below $\tau$, so SAL dev recall before Stage C is 89.4% instead of 90.0%.

**Smaller LLMs.** To test how the comparison depends on model size, we repeat the funnel and the whole-paper baseline with Qwen3.5-4B (`Qwen/Qwen3.5-4B`, revision `851bf6e8`, bfloat16), served with vLLM using the same prompts and decoding settings but without speculative decoding. The 4B model sometimes returned 19 verdicts for a batch of 20 candidates; for such batches we asked again for the missing candidates alone, as the funnel's filter does, and no verdict remained missing.

**Supervised classifiers on SAL.** To test whether a training-free Stage B is enough, we compare it with classifiers trained on SAL's own labels. We trained eight classifiers on the SAL training split: three fine-tuned encoders, PubMedBERT [35] (`BiomedNLP-BiomedBERT-base-uncased-abstract-fulltext`), SciBERT [36] and DistilBERT [37], each trained for three epochs (learning rate $3 \times 10^{-5}$, batch 32, class-weighted loss) with a decision threshold chosen on SAL dev; and five frozen sentence encoders [38, 39] with a logistic-regression classifier. PubMedBERT had the highest $F_1$ on SAL-40, and we use it as the supervised Stage B. Because this choice was made on the test split, it favours the supervised comparison.

**Stage B fine-tuned on LLM labels.** We also fine-tuned the NLI model itself on the gold training split. Each training sentence is paired with each of the three hypotheses, labelled entailment when its gold type matches, neutral when it is a gap of another type and contradiction when it is not a gap. We trained on the 134 arXiv training papers only (33,404 sentences after Stage A, 2534 gaps), leaving out the 28 SAL-40 papers in the gold training split so that SAL-40 stays unseen. Settings were fixed before training: learning rate $10^{-5}$, batch 32, two epochs, 6% warm-up, weight decay 0.01, seed 0, one V100 GPU. The epoch with the highest precision on the gold validation split at the 90%-recall rule was kept (the first). Thresholds follow the same rule on each dataset's development data.

**Stage C call and answer format.** The funnel sends 20 candidates per call, each with its own context, and asks for a verdict on every one. We test two other call formats with the fine-tuned Stage B: one call per paper with all of the paper's candidates as numbered sentences (the call format of the whole-paper baseline, but with only the candidates), and the same with the paper's abstract placed before the candidates as context. Both return the ids of the sentences to keep. The arXiv abstracts were taken from the arXiv API and the SAL abstracts from the papers' abstract sections; FWS has no abstracts. Separately, we test the answer format alone: the funnel's 20-per-call requests, unchanged, but asking for the ids of the candidates to keep instead of a verdict on each.

**Other Stage B options on the gold corpus.** We also compare the NLI classifier with bge-small, a small sentence-embedding model [39], with a logistic-regression classifier trained on the gold training split, and with the same NLI model using one long hypothesis that covers all gap types, used alone without Stage C (threshold 0.75, chosen on validation).

### 3.6 Evaluation

**Metrics.** We report precision, recall and $F_1$ (their harmonic mean) for the positive class at the sentence level. Recall is computed over all positive sentences in the test papers, including those removed by Stage A, so the losses of every stage count. Sentences from the same paper are not independent, so we resample papers: confidence intervals (CIs) are 95% percentile intervals from 2000 bootstrap resamples of papers [40]. To compare two systems, we score both on the same resampled papers and report the CI of their difference, and call a difference significant when this interval excludes zero. The CIs are not corrected for the number of comparisons, so

individual significant differences should be read as descriptive. Comparisons with whole-paper prompting on the gold corpus use its 28 arXiv test papers, on which the baseline was run.

**Cost.** We measure cost as the number of LLM input and output tokens reported by the server, and as the summed time of the LLM calls, sent one at a time to one H100 GPU. The 27B whole-paper baseline ran on the second H100 GPU of the same server, in its own vLLM instance with the same model, revision and serving settings; its times are therefore only approximately comparable. The computation of Stages A and B, which use no LLM, is not included. The early 27B runs of the 20-per-call funnel did not log tokens; their input equals that of the logged 4B runs, because the prompts and tokenizer are the same.

**Run-to-run stability.** To measure how much LLM verdicts vary between identical runs, we repeated the high-recall run on the gold test candidates.

**Planned human study.** To measure precision against human judgement, we have designed a blind study. Two raters and an independent tie-breaker will label a frozen sample of 135 sentences, drawn from the high-precision output on arXiv and SAL-40 and from decoy sentences. Its results are not part of this version.

### 3.7 Software and use of generative AI

Experiments used Python with PyTorch, Hugging Face Transformers, sentence-transformers, scikit-learn and vLLM. The client environment is pinned in the repository's lock file; the LLM servers ran in a separate environment with vLLM 0.32.0 and PyTorch 2.13. Generative AI is part of the method in two places: Claude Opus 5.5 and Claude Sonnet 5.5 produced the gold-corpus labels, and Qwen models are the Stage C filter and the whole-paper baseline. The use of AI assistance in preparing the study and the manuscript is declared at the end of the paper.

## 4 Results

We report the results in the order of the research questions, followed by a study of the Stage C call format and two findings about the evaluation data. Unless stated otherwise, Stage C uses Qwen3.8-27B in high-precision mode, and results on the gold corpus use its provisional LLM labels.

### 4.1 Contribution of each stage (RQ1)

Stage C does most of the work (Table 3 and Figure 2).

- **Stage A** removes many sentences only where sections are informative. On SAL-40, keeping only Discussion and Conclusion sections removes 76% of the sentences and loses 2 of the 205 limitations. On the gold corpus, the junk filter removes 18% of the sentences and 3% of the gaps.
- **Stage B** raises precision by a factor of 2.7 to 3.6 and keeps 88–91% of all positives, close to the 90% recall its threshold targets on development data.
- **Stage C** raises precision by a further 37 percentage points on SAL-40, 28 on FWS and 63 on the gold corpus, and lowers recall by 6, 12 and 34 points. On the gold corpus, most of the lost recall falls on research gaps and limitations (Section 4.2).

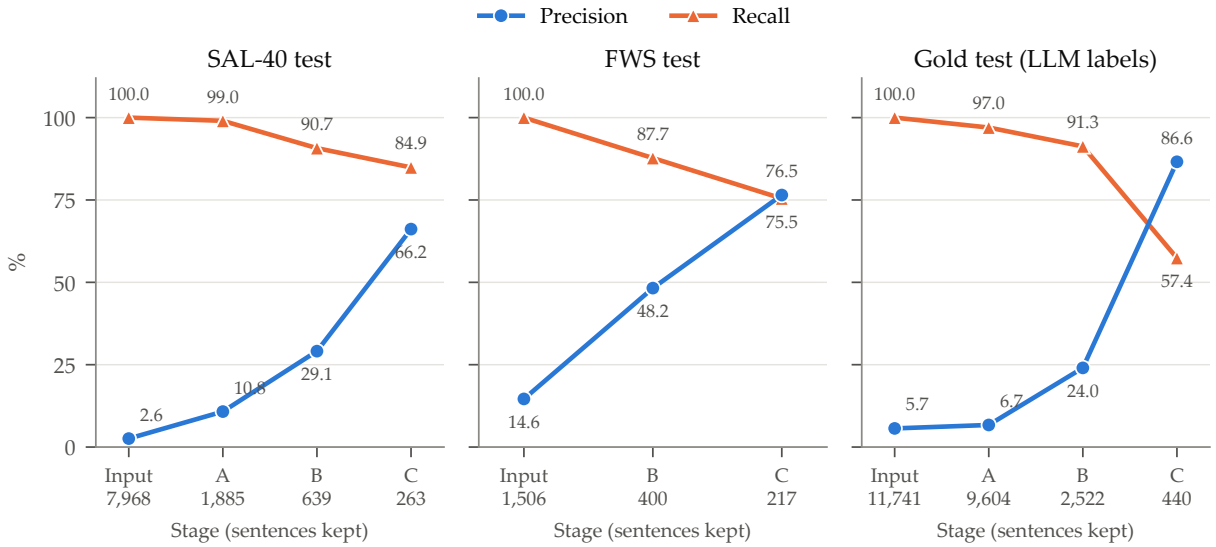



**Figure 2:** Precision and recall after each stage in high-precision mode. The number below each stage is the number of sentences it keeps. Gold results use LLM labels; FWS has no Stage A.

**Table 3:** Sentences kept after each stage. High-precision mode; precision and recall in %. Gold results use LLM labels.

| Dataset | After stage | Sentences | Positives | Precision | Recall |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAL-40 | Input | 7968 | 205 | 2.6 | 100 |
| | A. Discussion and Conclusion sections | 1885 | 203 | 10.8 | 99.0 |
| | B. NLI, $\tau = 0.7286$ | 639 | 186 | 29.1 | 90.7 |
| | C. LLM filter | 263 | 174 | 66.2 | 84.9 |
| FWS test | Input (no Stage A) | 1506 | 220 | 14.6 | 100 |
| | B. NLI, $\tau = 0.1922$ | 400 | 193 | 48.2 | 87.7 |
| | C. LLM filter | 217 | 166 | 76.5 | 75.5 |
| Gold test | Input | 11,741 | 664 | 5.7 | 100 |
| | A. Junk filter | 9604 | 644 | 6.7 | 97.0 |
| | B. NLI, $\tau = 0.354$ | 2522 | 606 | 24.0 | 91.3 |
| | C. LLM filter | 440 | 381 | 86.6 | 57.4 |

## 4.2 Precision control with three filter modes (RQ2)

Changing one paragraph of the instruction moves the filter along the precision–recall trade-off in the intended direction on every evaluation set (Table 4 and Figure 3): from high recall to balanced to high precision, precision rises and recall falls. In high-precision mode, precision is 66.2% on SAL-40, 76.5% on FWS and 86.6% on the gold test split (83.4% on its 28 arXiv papers and 97.1% on its six biomedical papers).

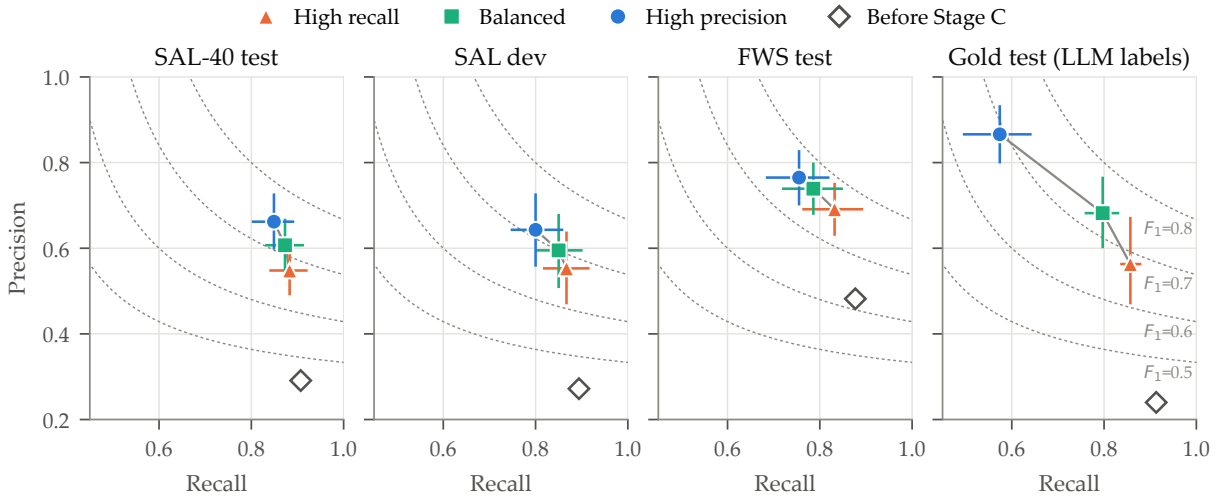



**Figure 3:** Precision against recall for the three filter modes and for the Stage B output before filtering, with 95% confidence intervals from resampling papers. Dotted curves connect points of equal $F_1$. Gold results use LLM labels.

The size of the trade-off differs between datasets. On SAL-40, high precision has the highest $F_1$ (0.744, against 0.716 for balanced and 0.677 for high recall). On FWS, precision rises from 69.1% to 76.5% while recall falls from 83.2% to 75.5%, so $F_1$ stays within 0.007. On the gold test split, balanced has the highest $F_1$: 0.055 above high recall (paired 95% CI 0.025 to 0.080) and 0.045 above high precision (0.006 to 0.095).

**By gap type.** High precision loses recall mainly on research gaps and limitations (Table 5). Future-work recall barely changes across modes (82.5–86.6%), whereas research-gap recall falls from 89.3% in high-recall mode to 51.3% in high-precision mode, and limitation recall from 79.5% to 55.9%. Research gaps are about half of the gold labels, so they weigh heavily on the overall scores: when sentences labelled as research gaps are excluded from scoring, high precision has the highest $F_1$ of the three modes (0.701, against 0.595 for balanced and 0.509 for high recall).

**Checks.** The ordering of the modes also holds outside the test sets. On SAL dev, whose papers influenced no prompt, high-precision mode reaches 64.3% precision, 80.0% recall and $F_1$ 0.713, close to SAL-40. On the gold validation split, where the modes were checked before the test runs, high-precision mode kept 60.3% of the labelled gaps among the Stage B candidates and rejected 97.7% of the other candidates, against 94.1% and 82.9% in high-recall mode. Removing the 196 gold test candidates used during development lowers $F_1$ slightly in every mode, from 0.690 to 0.675 in high-precision mode, 0.735 to 0.723 in balanced mode and 0.679 to 0.664 in high-recall mode. Removing the 27 papers they came from would leave only 7 test papers, too few to evaluate. Repeating the high-recall run with the same inputs and seed changed 32 of the 2522 verdicts (1.3%); $F_1$ was 0.678 in one run and 0.679 in the other.

**Table 4:** Results of the three filter modes. Precision and recall in %, with 95% confidence intervals from resampling papers. Gold results use LLM labels. Kept: number of sentences returned.

| Evaluation set | Mode | Kept | Precision | Recall | $F_1$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAL-40 test (human labels) | Before Stage C | 639 | 29.1 (26.2–32.1) | 90.7 (86.7–94.5) | 0.441 (0.404–0.475) |
| | High precision | 263 | 66.2 (59.7–72.8) | 84.9 (80.1–89.3) | 0.744 (0.695–0.789) |
| | Balanced | 295 | 60.7 (54.6–66.9) | 87.3 (83.0–91.4) | 0.716 (0.670–0.760) |
| | High recall | 330 | 54.8 (49.0–61.3) | 88.3 (83.9–92.2) | 0.677 (0.627–0.725) |
| SAL dev (human labels) | Before Stage C | 591 | 27.2 (23.3–31.5) | 89.4 (85.1–93.5) | 0.418 (0.369–0.468) |
| | High precision | 224 | 64.3 (55.7–72.8) | 80.0 (74.6–86.0) | 0.713 (0.647–0.774) |
| | Balanced | 257 | 59.5 (50.7–68.0) | 85.0 (79.9–90.2) | 0.700 (0.628–0.764) |
| | High recall | 282 | 55.3 (46.9–63.9) | 86.7 (81.6–91.7) | 0.675 (0.602–0.742) |
| FWS test (human labels) | Before Stage C | 400 | 48.2 (42.2–54.5) | 87.7 (81.1–93.4) | 0.623 (0.565–0.677) |
| | High precision | 217 | 76.5 (70.0–82.9) | 75.5 (68.3–82.1) | 0.760 (0.705–0.807) |
| | Balanced | 234 | 73.9 (67.8–80.0) | 78.6 (71.8–85.0) | 0.762 (0.709–0.808) |
| | High recall | 265 | 69.1 (62.9–75.3) | 83.2 (76.2–89.4) | 0.755 (0.702–0.804) |
| Gold test, all (LLM labels) | High precision | 440 | 86.6 (79.8–93.4) | 57.4 (49.4–64.3) | 0.690 (0.619–0.748) |
| | Balanced | 776 | 68.2 (60.0–76.7) | 79.7 (75.8–83.3) | 0.735 (0.678–0.789) |
| | High recall | 1,011 | 56.3 (46.9–67.3) | 85.7 (83.5–88.1) | 0.679 (0.604–0.756) |
| Gold test, arXiv (LLM labels) | High precision | 337 | 83.4 (76.0–91.3) | 53.3 (44.4–61.1) | 0.650 (0.573–0.713) |
| | Balanced | 643 | 64.2 (56.0–73.6) | 78.4 (73.8–82.6) | 0.706 (0.647–0.765) |
| | High recall | 862 | 51.7 (42.8–62.7) | 84.6 (82.1–87.2) | 0.642 (0.567–0.719) |
| Gold test, biomedical (LLM labels) | High precision | 103 | 97.1 (94.5–99.0) | 73.0 (63.7–81.0) | 0.833 (0.761–0.885) |
| | Balanced | 133 | 87.2 (82.4–92.2) | 84.7 (80.5–87.7) | 0.859 (0.833–0.889) |
| | High recall | 149 | 82.6 (80.2–86.1) | 89.8 (85.7–94.4) | 0.860 (0.839–0.894) |

**Table 5:** Gold test split by gap type (LLM labels). Recall for each type, and scores when research-gap sentences are excluded from scoring; in % except $F_1$.

| | Recall by type | | | Without research gaps | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mode | Limitation (220) | Future work (97) | Research gap (347) | Precision | Recall | $F_1$ |
| High precision | 55.9 | 82.5 | 51.3 | 77.5 | 64.0 | 0.701 |
| Balanced | 71.4 | 84.5 | 83.6 | 49.2 | 75.4 | 0.595 |
| High recall | 79.5 | 86.6 | 89.3 | 36.9 | 81.7 | 0.509 |

### 4.3 Funnel versus whole-paper prompting (RQ3)

The natural alternative to the funnel is to give the LLM the whole paper. Table 6 and Figure 4 compare the two with the same model, prompt and mode.

**Table 6:** Funnel versus whole-paper prompting. $F_1$ of each with the same LLM and mode, and their paired difference (funnel minus whole paper) with its 95% CI; bold: the CI excludes zero. On FWS the whole-paper baseline has one prompt for all modes (Section 3.5). arXiv results use LLM labels.

| | | Qwen3.8-27B | | | Qwen3.5-4B | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Set** | **Mode** | Whole | Funnel | Funnel − whole | Whole | Funnel | Funnel − whole |
| arXiv (28 papers, LLM labels) | High precision | 0.679 | 0.650 | −0.029 [−0.10, +0.04] | 0.296 | 0.544 | **+0.248** [+0.07, +0.35] |
| | Balanced | 0.749 | 0.706 | −0.043 [−0.09, +0.02] | 0.314 | 0.524 | **+0.210** [+0.04, +0.32] |
| | High recall | 0.741 | 0.642 | **−0.099** [−0.16, −0.03] | 0.275 | 0.480 | **+0.205** [+0.01, +0.27] |
| SAL-40 (human labels) | High precision | 0.702 | 0.744 | +0.042 [−0.01, +0.10] | 0.661 | 0.650 | −0.012 [−0.08, +0.06] |
| | Balanced | 0.673 | 0.716 | +0.043 [−0.01, +0.09] | 0.618 | 0.611 | −0.007 [−0.09, +0.07] |
| | High recall | 0.663 | 0.677 | +0.014 [−0.04, +0.06] | 0.599 | 0.576 | −0.023 [−0.10, +0.04] |
| FWS (human labels) | High precision | 0.694 | 0.760 | **+0.065** [+0.02, +0.11] | 0.719 | 0.727 | +0.009 [−0.04, +0.07] |
| | Balanced | ″ | 0.762 | **+0.068** [+0.02, +0.12] | ″ | 0.711 | −0.008 [−0.06, +0.05] |
| | High recall | ″ | 0.755 | **+0.060** [+0.02, +0.11] | ″ | 0.731 | +0.013 [−0.04, +0.06] |

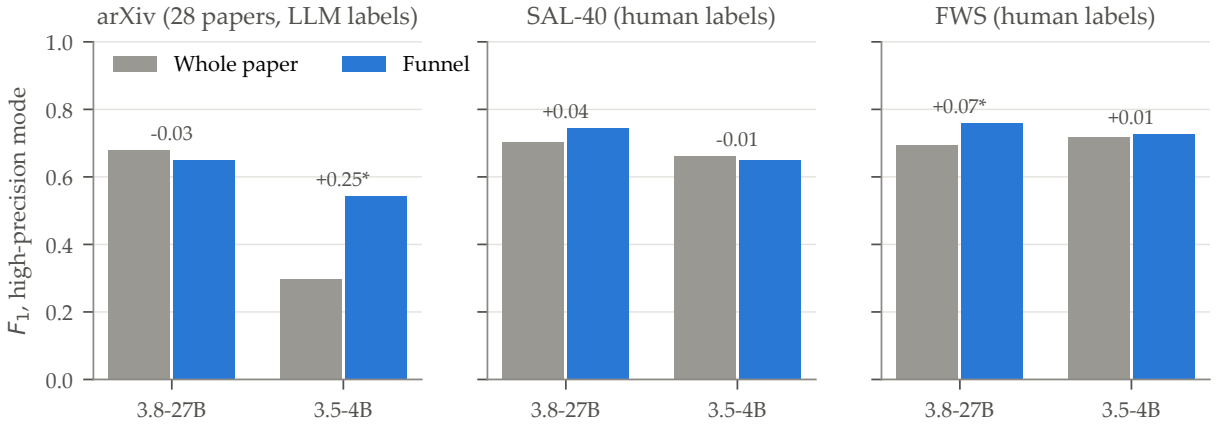



**Figure 4:** $F_1$ in high-precision mode for whole-paper prompting (grey) and the funnel (blue) with each LLM. Numbers give the funnel's advantage; an asterisk marks a paired 95% CI that excludes zero. arXiv results use LLM labels.

**With a strong LLM.** With Qwen3.8-27B, the funnel has higher $F_1$ than whole-paper prompting on both human-labelled benchmarks. On SAL-40 it is ahead by 0.014 to 0.043, which is not significant. In high-precision mode the funnel reaches 66.2% precision and 84.9% recall; the whole paper reaches 64.1% and 77.6%. On FWS the funnel is ahead by 0.060 to 0.068, significantly in every mode, but the FWS baseline's single prompt also accepts limitations. On the arXiv papers the order reverses: whole-paper prompting is better in every mode, significantly in high-recall mode (−0.099). The other ways of splitting the paper behave the same way. Chunks of 100 sentences reach $F_1$ 0.70–0.73 on arXiv and 0.60–0.68 on SAL-40, and batches of 20 consecutive sentences 0.70–0.72 and 0.55–0.64, so both are ahead of the funnel on arXiv and behind it on SAL-40, while using more input tokens than the whole paper.

**With a smaller LLM.** Small models need the funnel. With Qwen3.5-4B, whole-paper prompting breaks down on arXiv papers: in high-precision mode it reaches only 20.7% precision and 52.2%

recall ($F_1$ 0.296). On long papers the model returns most of the paper, for example 490 of 692 sentences. On the longest paper (1526 sentences, 83 gaps) its answer exceeded the output limit in every mode, but this is not the main cause: without that paper, $F_1$ is still 0.29–0.33. The funnel, which never sends the model more than 20 candidates at a time, reaches $F_1$ 0.544 with the same model, an advantage of 0.21 to 0.25 that is significant in every mode. On SAL-40 and FWS, whose inputs are shorter, the 4B model works well on whole papers and the two approaches do not differ significantly.

**Paper length.** Splitting the arXiv papers at their median length (239 sentences) shows the same pattern within one dataset. On the 14 shorter papers, whole-paper prompting is ahead in high-precision mode with both models ($F_1$ 0.707 against 0.624 for the 27B model, 0.658 against 0.595 for the 4B model). On the 14 longer papers, the funnel is level with the 27B model (0.668 against 0.659) and far ahead with the 4B model (0.516 against 0.203). The smaller the model and the longer the paper, the more the funnel helps.

**Cost.** The funnel uses about a third of the input tokens of whole-paper prompting on SAL-40 and FWS, and 1.4 times fewer on arXiv, where each of the 2137 candidates carries its own context (Table 7). Its output is larger, because it returns a verdict for every candidate rather than a list of kept sentences; with the 4B model this makes it slower than whole-paper prompting on arXiv (198 against 160 seconds of LLM time). The chunked and every-sentence baselines are more expensive than the whole paper: with the 27B model they used 0.58–0.76 million input tokens on arXiv and 0.36–0.48 million on SAL-40. Section 4.5 shows a call format that removes most of the funnel's cost.

**Table 7:** Measured LLM cost in high-precision mode: input tokens (the same prompts for every model), output tokens and summed call time in seconds, one call at a time on one H100 GPU. arXiv: the 28 arXiv test papers; for the 20-per-call funnel, whose batches mix arXiv and SAL papers, each batch is counted by its share of arXiv candidates. The one-call-per-paper funnel uses the fine-tuned Stage B (Section 4.5). The early 27B runs of the 20-per-call funnel did not log output or time (n/a).

| | | | **Qwen3.8-27B** | | **Qwen3.5-4B** | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Set** | **Setup** | **Input** | Output | Seconds | Output | Seconds |
| arXiv | Whole paper | 554k | 1.6k | 104 | 6.0k | 160 |
| | Funnel, 20 per call | 403k | n/a | n/a | 23k | 198 |
| | Funnel, one call per paper | 75k | 1.4k | 31 | 2.1k | 24 |
| SAL-40 | Whole paper | 348k | 1.5k | 65 | 1.5k | 30 |
| | Funnel, 20 per call | 106k | n/a | n/a | 6.4k | 54 |
| | Funnel, one call per paper | 42k | 1.1k | 27 | 0.9k | 20 |
| FWS | Whole paper | 183k | 2.7k | 89 | 2.1k | 72 |
| | Funnel, 20 per call | 62k | n/a | n/a | 4.0k | 34 |
| | Funnel, one call per paper | 67k | 1.3k | 59 | 1.1k | 47 |

## 4.4 Choice of Stage B (RQ4)

**Supervised classifier.** We ran the funnel in all three modes with PubMedBERT, trained on SAL's own labels, as Stage B. Before Stage C, PubMedBERT selects 391 candidates with 46.0% precision and 87.8% recall ($F_1$ 0.604); it was the best of the eight SAL-trained classifiers (SciBERT 0.553, DistilBERT 0.523, frozen encoders 0.371–0.457). After Stage C in high-precision mode it reaches 74.5% precision (95% CI 68.4–80.7), 78.5% recall and $F_1$ 0.765.

With PubMedBERT, the funnel is 6.9 to 9.0 points more precise in every mode (Table 8). In high-precision mode the $F_1$ difference is small and not significant (−0.021, CI −0.053 to +0.014);

in the other two modes PubMedBERT's advantage is larger (0.035 and 0.059). The training-free classifier is therefore competitive in $F_1$ in high-precision mode but not in precision. The NLI model's weights were not fitted on any SAL label; only its threshold was set on SAL dev.

**Table 8:** SAL-40, NLI versus PubMedBERT as Stage B. Left: the funnel with NLI minus the funnel with PubMedBERT in the same mode, paired over resampled papers; precision differences in points, 95% CI in brackets. Right: precision of the NLI funnel's output against the LLM labels instead of SAL's human labels (Section 4.6.1), in %.

| | NLI minus PubMedBERT | | Precision against LLM labels | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Mode** | **Precision** | $F_1$ | **Limitation** | **Any gap type** |
| High precision | −8.4 (−11.8, −4.5) | −0.021 (−0.053, +0.014) | 93.2 | 95.1 |
| Balanced | −6.9 (−11.5, −2.3) | −0.035 (−0.068, 0.000) | 88.8 | 91.2 |
| High recall | −9.0 (−12.7, −5.1) | −0.059 (−0.089, −0.027) | 81.8 | 85.2 |

**Fine-tuning on LLM labels.** Fine-tuning the NLI model on the gold training labels makes Stage B more precise against those labels but not against human labels. At the same 90%-recall rule, it cuts the gold test candidates from 2522 to 1998 and raises their precision from 24.0% to 30.4% at 91.4% recall. On SAL-40 and FWS it is slightly worse than the zero-shot model: 702 instead of 639 candidates at 26.6% instead of 29.1% precision on SAL-40, and 45.7% instead of 48.2% precision on FWS. After Stage C (Table 9), the fine-tuned funnel improves $F_1$ on the gold test split by 0.025 to 0.027 (significant in the high-recall and balanced modes) but not on SAL-40 or FWS (−0.019 to +0.002, none significant). One explanation is that the model learned how the LLM labellers mark gaps; differences in domain and input form between the training papers and the benchmarks may also contribute.

**Other options on the gold corpus.** On the half of the gold validation papers not used to choose the hypotheses, the three short hypotheses reached 39.2% precision at about 79% recall, whereas the bge-small classifier trained on the gold training split reached 28.2% at the same recall. On the test split, the funnel in high-precision mode has higher $F_1$ than the NLI model used alone with one long hypothesis (0.690 against 0.614; difference 0.076, CI 0.020 to 0.132), and does not differ significantly from a funnel with the bge-small classifier as Stage B and the high-recall filter ($F_1$ 0.665; difference +0.025, CI −0.037 to +0.087).

## 4.5 Stage C call and answer format

**Table 9:** Funnel variants. $F_1$ of whole-paper prompting and of three funnels, by LLM; each cell gives high precision / balanced / high recall. On FWS the whole-paper baseline has one prompt for all modes. arXiv results use LLM labels.

| **Set** | **Setup** | **Qwen3.8-27B** | **Qwen3.5-4B** |
|---|---|---|---|
| arXiv | Whole paper | 0.679 / 0.749 / 0.741 | 0.296 / 0.314 / 0.275 |
| | Funnel (zero-shot NLI, 20 per call) | 0.650 / 0.706 / 0.642 | 0.544 / 0.524 / 0.480 |
| | Fine-tuned NLI, 20 per call | 0.687 / 0.734 / 0.674 | 0.591 / 0.595 / 0.514 |
| | Fine-tuned NLI, one call per paper | 0.642 / 0.687 / 0.691 | 0.484 / 0.460 / 0.530 |
| SAL-40 | Whole paper | 0.702 / 0.673 / 0.663 | 0.661 / 0.618 / 0.599 |
| | Funnel (zero-shot NLI, 20 per call) | 0.744 / 0.716 / 0.677 | 0.650 / 0.611 / 0.576 |
| | Fine-tuned NLI, 20 per call | 0.725 / 0.713 / 0.674 | 0.660 / 0.611 / 0.565 |
| | Fine-tuned NLI, one call per paper | 0.720 / 0.705 / 0.673 | 0.711 / 0.708 / 0.697 |
| FWS | Whole paper | 0.694 / 0.694 / 0.694 | 0.719 / 0.719 / 0.719 |
| | Funnel (zero-shot NLI, 20 per call) | 0.760 / 0.762 / 0.755 | 0.727 / 0.711 / 0.731 |
| | Fine-tuned NLI, 20 per call | 0.759 / 0.764 / 0.736 | 0.713 / 0.693 / 0.703 |
| | Fine-tuned NLI, one call per paper | 0.749 / 0.736 / 0.723 | 0.725 / 0.721 / 0.741 |

**One call per paper.** Sending all of a paper's candidates in one call, numbered like the whole-paper baseline, uses 7.4 times fewer input tokens than whole-paper prompting on arXiv and 8.3 times fewer on SAL-40, with no more output, and 1.5 to 7 times less LLM time (Table 7). Its accuracy depends on the model (Table 9). With the 27B model it matches the 20-per-call format on SAL-40 (differences of $-0.001$ to $-0.008$) and is 0.01 to 0.05 lower on FWS and in two of the three arXiv modes. With the 4B model it is the best or tied-best setup on the human-labelled benchmarks: on SAL-40 it is ahead of whole-paper prompting by 0.050 to 0.098 (significant in the balanced and high-recall modes), with higher precision (67.1% against 56.8% in high-precision mode). Placing the paper's abstract before the candidates did not help; it lowered $F_1$ by up to 0.02 in every mode with the 27B model.

**Answer format.** Asking for the list of candidates to keep instead of a verdict on each, with everything else unchanged, cuts output tokens four- to sevenfold but changes 7.6–9.3% of the verdicts, whereas repeating identical calls changes 0.4%. The model keeps more candidates in this format: precision in high-precision mode falls from 86.6% to 79.2% on the gold test split, at a similar $F_1$ (differences of $-0.023$ to $+0.006$, none significant).

### 4.6 Two checks on the evaluation data

Two properties of the data change how the results should be read.

#### 4.6.1 Precision depends on the label source

The precision of the same output changes greatly with the reference labels. Of the 263 sentences returned in high-precision mode on SAL-40, SAL's annotators marked 174 as limitations, whereas the LLM ensemble marked 245 as limitations and 250 as a gap of some type. The two label sets disagree mainly on 77 sentences that are gaps according to the LLM labels but not according to SAL; only 12 returned sentences are negative under both. Precision is therefore 66.2% against SAL and 93.2–95.1% against the LLM labels (right side of Table 8). Which value is closer to the truth depends on who is right about these 77 sentences, which the planned human study is designed to settle.

#### 4.6.2 Letter case reveals the label in FWS

In the FWS recognition corpus as we obtained it (64,896 sentences from 9013 papers), all 9009 positive sentences are entirely lowercase, and almost no negative sentence is. The rule "a sentence is positive if it is all lowercase" therefore reaches 99.8% precision and 100% recall. Our copy has the same size in bytes as the published file [30], so the artefact appears to be present in the released corpus, although we did not compare the two files directly. Any case-sensitive model, and any LLM that sees the raw text, can exploit this signal. All FWS results in this paper therefore use lowercased text, and we do not use an earlier FWS result of ours that was obtained on raw text.

## 5 Discussion

We first interpret the answers to the research questions. We then discuss when whole-paper prompting is enough, how reliable the extracted gaps are, why section rules do not transfer to computer-science papers, and what the results imply for evaluation data. The section ends with the limitations of the study.

### 5.1 Answers to the research questions

**RQ1: each stage has its own role.** Stage A is cheap and useful only where section headings are informative. Stage B sets the ceiling on recall, because Stage C only removes candidates and cannot recover a gap that Stage B missed. Stage C provides most of the gain in precision. Every reported gap remains a sentence the authors wrote.

**RQ2: one instruction sets the trade-off.** The three modes kept their order on every evaluation set, on held-out SAL dev papers and on the gold validation split before any test run. The funnel can therefore be set for its use: high precision for idea generation, where every false gap costs a downstream model or a person time, and high recall for a reviewer who wants to see every candidate. High precision costs recall mostly on research gaps. A possible reason, which we have not tested, is that the high-precision instruction asks the model to drop background and motivation, and authors often state open problems in exactly that role.

**RQ3: the funnel matters most for small models and long papers.** With a strong model, the funnel was as accurate as whole-paper prompting or more so on the two human-labelled benchmarks, at about a third of the input tokens, and less accurate on arXiv papers against LLM labels. With a 4B model, whole-paper prompting failed on long papers and the funnel did not. A filter in front of the LLM matters little for a strong model on short documents and a great deal for a small model on long ones.

**RQ4: a training-free Stage B is a good default.** A zero-shot NLI classifier needs no gap-labelled data and works on biomedical and computer-science text. Where human labels exist, a supervised classifier is still worth training: on SAL it was 6.9 to 9.0 points more precise in every mode. This comparison is available only for SAL. Fine-tuning on LLM labels did not substitute for human labels.

### 5.2 When is whole-paper prompting enough?

Three factors decide the comparison in our data.

- **Input length.** SAL papers have about 200 sentences and FWS excerpts about seven; arXiv papers have a median of 239 and up to 1526, with whole-paper inputs of up to 72,000 tokens. The 4B model handled the short inputs and failed on the long ones, mostly by returning a large part of the paper. Within arXiv, the funnel helped on the longer half of the papers and not on the shorter half.
- **Model size.** The 27B model handled every input, so its gains on SAL-40 and FWS come from the narrower task the funnel gives it, not from making the input fit. The 27B and 4B models also belong to different Qwen generations (3.8 and 3.5), so size is not the only difference between them.
- **Reference labels.** The arXiv labels were produced by LLMs that read each whole paper in one call, the same input format as the whole-paper baseline, and may therefore favour it. On the two benchmarks labelled by people, the funnel was ahead with the 27B model.

The comparison is not perfectly matched in two further ways. On SAL, Stage A uses section labels that the whole-paper baseline does not see. On FWS, the baseline used an older prompt that also accepts limitations. Both favour the funnel; the arXiv label provenance favours the baseline.

The call format also matters. The funnel's main cost on arXiv is that each candidate carries its own context and receives its own verdict. Sending each paper's candidates in a single call

removes most of this cost, and with the 4B model it was the most accurate setup on SAL-40. With the 27B model, however, it lost up to 0.05 $F_1$ on arXiv, and asking for a list of kept sentences instead of a verdict on each candidate made the model less selective. Cheaper formats are a trade-off rather than a free improvement.

### 5.3 How reliable are the extracted gaps?

How good the extracted gaps are depends on which labels are trusted. On SAL-40, high-precision mode reaches 66.2% precision against SAL's labels and 93.2% against the LLM labels. Either label set may be wrong on the 77 sentences where they disagree. SAL's annotators may have left some limitation statements unlabelled. The LLM labels are inclusive by construction, because adjudication added sentences that only one model had marked. The two values describe the same output under two references; neither is a bound on its true precision.

Label errors may also affect the gold corpus. In an earlier high-recall run during development, not part of the results above, five of the 34 test papers accounted for 59% of the false positives. Each had only about 18–24 gold gaps despite having 220 to 824 sentences, which may indicate that long papers are under-labelled. If so, recall on long papers is understated for every system, and precision against these labels is understated most for systems that keep many sentences.

The planned human study (Section 3) will measure precision against human judgement on a frozen sample from arXiv and SAL-40.

### 5.4 Section rules do not transfer to computer-science papers

In RCT reports, limitations cluster in the Discussion and Conclusion sections, so a section rule works. In arXiv papers it did not, in our development work. An earlier localiser kept only the sections where gaps are usually stated, such as the discussion and the conclusion. Measured against the limitation and future-work labels of the arXiv papers, with a fuzzy sentence match, it kept only 55.6% of these gaps when sections were inferred from the extracted text and 55.2% when sections were taken from the LaTeX sources of 175 papers. Better section information did not help: with LaTeX sections, 82% of the missed gaps were in methods, experiments or results sections. This development analysis used a different target and matching rule from our main evaluation and was not repeated for this version. For arXiv papers we therefore use only the junk filter as Stage A, which keeps 97% of the gold test gaps, and leave the narrowing to Stage B.

### 5.5 Evaluation data needs checking

The FWS case artefact shows that a published benchmark can contain a trivial signal that a modern model will find. FWS results from case-sensitive models, or from LLMs given the raw text, including an earlier result of ours, should be treated with caution unless the text is normalised. More generally, the precision we measure on SAL-40 changed more with the label source than with the choice of Stage B. Stating which labels a number rests on is as important as reporting the number.

### 5.6 Limitations

- **LLM labels.** All results on the gold corpus rest on labels produced by Claude models, which have not yet been checked by people. The agreement between the two labelling models ($\kappa = 0.778$) measures their consistency, not their accuracy. Claude models also assisted in writing the prompts and this manuscript, so the labels and the prompts may share biases.
- **Development on test papers.** The Stage C model, batch size, use of context and high-recall instruction were chosen on 196 candidates from 27 of the 34 gold test papers, and the

balanced and high-precision instructions were written after reading false positives on gold test papers. We report results without these candidates, ran and report all modes on every dataset, and checked the modes on the validation split first; still, the gold test split is not untouched. SAL dev provides the cleanest held-out check, and its results agree with those on SAL-40.

- **Comparisons designed later.** The comparisons with whole-paper prompting, a smaller model and other formats were designed after the main results were known. The whole-paper baseline was frozen before its test runs, and all runs of these comparisons are reported.
- **Statistics.** Each configuration was run once, and the many paired comparisons are not corrected for multiplicity. Differences below about 0.03 $F_1$ should not be read as real effects.
- **Scope.** SAL covers RCT reports only, FWS covers NLP conclusion sections only, and each labels a single gap type. The six biomedical papers in the gold test split are also SAL papers. The arXiv papers are a convenience sample of 28 test papers. Stage C was tested with one model family.
- **Research gaps.** Half of the gold labels are research gaps, which the earlier stages retain better than the other types; we therefore also report recall by type and scores without research gaps.
- **Published methods.** Reproductions of published extraction methods on our splits are not yet included.
- **Cost.** Cost is measured as LLM tokens and call time on our hardware, not in money, and excludes Stages A and B.

## 6 Conclusions

We presented a three-stage funnel that extracts author-stated research gaps as unmodified source sentences: rules remove text that is unlikely to contain gaps, a zero-shot NLI classifier selects candidates without gap-labelled training data, and an LLM filter removes false positives in one of three modes set by a single instruction.

On the two human-labelled benchmarks, high-precision mode reached 66.2% precision at 84.9% recall for limitations in RCT reports (SAL-40) and 76.5% precision at 75.5% recall for future work in NLP conclusion sections (FWS), and held-out SAL papers gave similar results. The modes shifted precision and recall in the intended direction on every dataset. On our gold corpus, whose labels come from LLMs and are not yet checked by people, high-precision mode agreed with 86.6% of its kept sentences at 57.4% recall.

Compared with giving the same 27B LLM the whole paper, the funnel had higher $F_1$ on both human-labelled benchmarks, significantly on FWS, with about a third of the input tokens; whole-paper prompting was better on arXiv papers against LLM labels. With a 4B LLM, whole-paper prompting broke down on long arXiv papers and the funnel did not. In our experiments, a filter in front of the LLM is most useful where the model is small and the documents are long.

The next steps are the human validation of the gold corpus, comparisons with published extraction methods, and the use of the extracted gaps for automated research-idea generation.

## Data Availability

Code, prompts, evaluation scripts, the gold-corpus labels and paper splits, and the exact SAL and FWS evaluation splits are openly available at `https://github.com/Yazangthb/Gap2Idea` [41].

The gold-corpus labels were produced by language models and have not yet been validated by people. The SAL data [29] and the FWS corpus [30] were created by their authors and remain subject to their original terms; copies are included in the repository so that the evaluation can be reproduced. The arXiv papers are available from arXiv; the repository includes the text we extracted from them and their abstracts. All LLM verdicts behind the reported results are included, for the funnel, the whole-paper baseline and every model size. The FWS split depends on an earlier training file of ours, `data/scibert_prep/train.jsonl` (SHA-256 prefix `f8d5fd58c5b9f1bb`), which is also included.

## Use of Generative AI

During the preparation of this study and manuscript, the authors used Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic), through Claude Code, to write and run analysis code and to draft and edit text. The authors have reviewed and edited the output and take full responsibility for the content of this publication.


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## A Stage C prompt

The system prompt used on the gold corpus is reproduced below. The three modes differ only in the paragraph marked [MODE], whose three versions are listed after the prompt. For SAL and FWS, the decision rule keeps only item (a) or item (b), respectively; the other two items are added to the list of sentences to drop, and the words "gap" and "research gap" are replaced by "limitation" or "future-work direction". All prompts are in the code repository (`scripts/bench/stage_c_rubric_val.py`, `stage_c_sal40_modes.py`, `nli_sal_fws.py`).

> You are a precision filter for a research-gap extraction pipeline. Judge each candidate sentence: does it genuinely state a research gap?
>
> Each item has: "i" (integer id), "type" (the predicted gap type), "sentence" (the candidate to judge), and "context" (surrounding text). Judge the "sentence", using "context" only to disambiguate.
>
> Decision — answer YES (keep) if the sentence states ANY of: (a) a limitation / weakness / caveat / bias / constraint / assumption of the authors' OWN work (e.g., small sample, no blinding, single setting, short follow-up, confounding, limited generalizability, unvalidated measure, "we did not / could not . . . ", "a limitation is . . . "); (b) an explicit FUTURE-WORK direction the authors propose ("in future work we will . . . ", "future research should . . . ", "it would be interesting to . . . "); (c) an unsolved problem / missing capability / open research gap in the field or prior work ("it remains unknown . . . ", "no existing method . . . ", "current approaches struggle with . . . ").
>
> Answer NO (drop) if the sentence is instead: a result or finding, a method/experimental-setup description, a positive or contribution claim ("we propose/show/achieve . . . "), background or related-work description, a citation or reference fragment, acknowledgements / funding / author contributions / competing interests, a figure or table caption, a dataset/metric definition, or a generic non-gap statement.
>
> [MODE]
>
> Return JSON of the form {"results":[{"id":<i>, "keep":<bool>}, . . . ]} with EXACTLY one entry per input item, where id is the item's "i" and keep=true means YES.

The [MODE] paragraph:

- **High recall:** "Be KEEP-BIASED: when you are genuinely uncertain whether a sentence is a real gap, answer YES. Only answer NO when it clearly is NOT a gap by the rules above."
- **Balanced:** "Judge each sentence on the rules above, without favouring YES or NO."
- **High precision (main mode):** "Be STRICT. Answer YES only when the sentence itself explicitly states the limitation, the proposed direction, or the unsolved problem. Also answer NO for: a general property or difficulty of a method or domain given as background or motivation; a statement of why the authors' approach is needed; an observed experimental outcome; and a passing remark that names no specific gap. When genuinely uncertain, answer NO."

**Whole-paper and one-call-per-paper prompts.** The whole-paper baseline and the one-call-per-paper funnel use the same prompt with some sentences replaced. The whole-paper prompt also replaces the opening line, which reads "You are reading sentences from scientific papers. Judge each sentence:". The description of the items is replaced by a description of the numbered input ("one per line as [id] sentence"; for the one-call-per-paper funnel, "the candidate sentences of ONE scientific paper . . . Sentences between candidates were removed"), and the output line asks for {"positives":[<id>, . . . ]}, the ids of every sentence answered YES, in increasing order. The exact texts are in `scripts/bench/stage_c_per_paper_ft.py` and in the frozen plan of the whole-paper baseline (`docs/experiments/baseline_qwen/prompts/`).

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